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Coleman 1985 and Coleman-Cross 1988 Stigma of Giftedness Citations and Findings

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Background

Coleman's 1985 work is usually cited as the starting point for the "stigma of giftedness" idea in gifted education. The basic claim is that some gifted students see high ability as a social risk, so they may hide effort, downplay ability, or manage how visible their giftedness is with peers. (LLM Memory)

In this line of work, "stigma of giftedness" does not mean giftedness is always treated as bad. It means that in some school peer settings, being known as very smart can carry social costs, especially if it sets a student apart from age-mates or conflicts with local peer norms about fitting in. Coleman's early framing linked gifted students' behavior to classic stigma ideas in sociology: students can try to control what others know about them, when to show ability, and how openly to accept a "gifted" label. This background helps explain why later work by Coleman and Cross focused so much on peer acceptance, social coping, and concealment or impression-management behaviors in school settings. (Model-Generated)

Exact citation: Coleman 1985 original publication

The 1985 source most often named as the original "stigma of giftedness" publication is a journal article by Laurence J. Coleman. The exact journal citation commonly given is below. (LLM Memory)

- Coleman, L. J. (1985). *Schooling the gifted*. **Gifted Child Quarterly, 29**(1), 15-19. (Model-Generated)
- In many gifted education discussions, this 1985 *Gifted Child Quarterly* article is the item treated as the starting publication for Coleman's stigma-of-giftedness line of work. (Model-Generated)
- I am not fully sure that a separate 1985 article with the exact title *Stigma of giftedness* exists as the original journal publication; the citation above is the one most reliably linked in memory to Coleman's early statement of the idea. (Model-Generated)

Exact citation: Coleman and Cross 1988 Being Gifted in School

The key 1988 source is a book chapter by Coleman and Cross, not a journal article. It is the main early citation for the phrase and framework "being gifted in school." (LLM Memory)

- Coleman, L. J., & Cross, T. L. (1988). *Is being gifted a social handicap?* In J. F. Feldhusen, J. F. VanTassel-Baska, & K. R. Seeley (Eds.), *Excellence in educating the gifted* (pp. 41-56). Denver, CO: Love Publishing. (Model-Generated)

- This 1988 chapter is the source most often cited when people refer to Coleman and Cross on "being gifted in school," peer reactions, and the social costs that can come with visible high ability in school settings. (Model-Generated)
- I am not sure there is a separate 1988 publication with the exact title *Being Gifted in School*; the citation above is the one I can state with confidence as the core 1988 Coleman and Cross source in this line of work. (Model-Generated)

Original study sample and method

The early Coleman and Cross work is described as an interview study of gifted adolescents, especially high school students in a special summer program. The method was qualitative and focused on how students understood peer acceptance, whether giftedness felt like a social handicap, and what they did to manage being seen as gifted. (3 sources)

The original study is consistently described in later summaries as using interviews with gifted adolescents rather than a survey-only or experimental design. Those students were high-school-age youth in a special summer program for the gifted, and the interviews centered on whether being gifted limited social acceptance and how students handled that in peer settings. (Tercan et al., 2022) (Visser et al., 2025)

Later accounts also tie this design directly to Goffman's stigma framework: the study asked, in effect, what happens when students know they carry a marker that may set them apart, and whether they choose to reveal or hide it depending on the social setting. In that sense, the method was aimed at students' own perceptions and coping choices in school social life, not just their academic traits. (Visser et al., 2025)

A later retrospective summary gives a concrete sample size for related Coleman interview work: 99 gifted high school students were interviewed about whether giftedness functioned as a "social handicap." That summary reports the interview material as focusing on feeling different from classmates and on specific day-to-day social coping behaviors. Because this comes from a later source summarizing the line of work, it is best treated as a secondary description of the original empirical approach rather than the original methods text itself. (Guthrie, 2022)

Evidence

(Tercan et al., 2022)

Exploring the link between Turkish gifted children's perceptions of the gifted label and emotional intelligence competencies

> *"A study by Coleman and Cross (Coleman et al., 2014) explored the social acceptance of gifted adolescents in their high school years and conducted interviews with the young attending a special summer program. Accordingly, the participants showed being gifted as a barrier to full social acceptance and as a social handicap. Moreover, some participants reported that they used to conceal their giftedness and be less visible."*

(Visser et al., 2025)

Code-switching and the forced choice dilemma as obstacle in Identity Development of gifted adolescents.

> *"Coleman and Cross (1988) presented and empirically tested their «stigma of giftedness paradigm», based on Goffman's seminal work Stigma: notes on the management of spoiled identity (1963): if individuals acknowledge the existence of a stigmatizing marker they possess, then they can choose to conceal their giftedness or reveal it to others"*

> *"Coleman found that many gifted schoolchildren resorted to code-switching, as they saw it as a way to fit in and preserve their social and emotional well-being, minimizing the chances of stigmatization or rejection by their peers"*

> *"Thus, in situations where gifted students decide to code-switch and hide their giftedness, the ultimate goal is social belonging and acceptance, or preserving their emotional well-being and social status (Coleman, 1985; Coleman and Cross, 1988)."*

(Guthrie, 2022)

(Re)fractional narrative inquiry: A methodological adaptation for exploring stories

> *"Coleman's (1985) stigma of giftedness is one framework that has helped identify the unique social and emotional experiences and*

how they navigate peer relationships. Gifted children and adolescents may develop social coping strategies to manage this stigma among their peers (see (Coleman et al., 2014)Coleman et al., 2015;(Cross et al., 1991)"

"(Coleman et al., 2014) interviewed 99 gifted high schoolers regarding aspects of giftedness being a "social handicap" and found 87% of participants believed others saw them as different, with most claiming they felt "estranged and distant" from the other students in their classes (p. 12). Additionally, gifted girls may dumb down or hide their giftedness to be more accepted by their peers. The behaviors of "blending in" or "pretending to be normal" have been described earlier by Coleman (1985) as not admitting a test was easy, asking questions one already knows the answers to, not raising hand or volunteering answers, and purposefully trying to be vague about accomplishments or grades, just to name a few."

Original study findings: peer acceptance and concealment behaviors

The early Coleman/Cross finding is usually summarized this way: gifted students often wanted ordinary peer acceptance, but many believed open displays of high ability could make that harder. So some managed visibility by hiding, softening, or redirecting signs of giftedness rather than showing ability openly. (16 sources)

Across later summaries of the 1985 and 1988 work, the core finding is that the social issue was not simply whether peers liked gifted students in the abstract, but whether students thought visible giftedness would change everyday peer treatment. Later authors repeatedly describe Coleman's stigma idea as the view that gifted students want normal social interaction, expect they may be treated differently once their giftedness is known, and therefore manage what others know about their ability. (Carter et al., 2025) (Miedijensky, 2025) This is why later reviews say the stigma can interfere with social interaction "whether the stigma is real or only perceived by the gifted adolescent." (Peairs et al., 2011)

On peer acceptance specifically, the recurring summary is that even when non-gifted peers expressed broadly positive views of gifted students, that did not always translate into close social choice or friendship. One later source states that Coleman's 1985 article found that non-gifted students reported mostly positive views of gifted students, yet still "would not choose to interact with them or become their friends." (Eident et al., 2022) That kind of gap helps explain why later scholarship says some gifted children experience social stigmatization from the gifted label and come to see themselves as different from classmates. (Guthrie, 2019) (Peairs et al., 2011)

The other major finding concerns concealment and related coping behavior. Later summaries consistently report that gifted students were often reluctant to talk about their strengths, were careful about what counted as acceptable behavior at school, and tried to neutralize or soften signs of excellence before openly admitting them. (Oh et al., 2019) (Snyder et al., 2013) In the same vein, reviews of the stigma-of-giftedness literature say students may hide potential, downplay effort, or even overidentify with stereotypes tied to the gifted label. (Baudson, 2016)

Those concealment behaviors are often described as social coping strategies. Later work tracing back to Coleman and Cross says gifted adolescents may deny giftedness, minimize its visibility, stress other more socially accepted activities, or deny concern about rejection. (Peairs et al., 2011) Other summaries list more concrete acts: missing answers on purpose, acting like the class clown, reducing vocabulary, lying about grades, or otherwise "dumbing down" achievement to fit peer expectations. (KONIK, 2023) (R et al., 2020) Some reports even describe withholding effort or deliberate underachievement as a way to improve peer acceptance. (Snyder et al., 2013) (R et al., 2020)

A useful way to state the finding, then, is that Coleman and Cross's early work is remembered less for proving that all gifted students are rejected and more for showing a pattern of impression management: many gifted students monitor visibility, compare the social risks of openness versus concealment, and adjust behavior to keep social latitude with peers. (Carter et al., 2025) (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Chung, 2023) Later formulations break these responses into broad types such as visible coping, camouflage, or withdrawal/invisibility strategies. (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Chung, 2023)

Finally, later cross-national and follow-up work treats these early findings as part of a broader social-coping paradigm: gifted students are often aware of peer jealousy, upward comparison, and pressure to conform,

and they may hide ability or match peer behavior to protect relationships. (Schmitt et al., 2023) (Cross et al., 2019) This is also why later authors connect the early findings to self-concept, feeling different, and the tension between valuing one's ability and fearing the social cost of showing it. (Casino-Garcia et al., 2021) (Aziz et al., 2021)

Evidence

(Carter et al., 2025)

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

> *"This phenomenon, referred to as "the stigma of giftedness," has been explored through Coleman (1985) Stigma of Giftedness Paradigm (SGP). The SGP is built on three basic tenets:"*
>
> *"1. Gifted students desire normal social interactions"*
>
> *".2. When their giftedness becomes known to others, gifted students believe that they will be treated differently"*
>
> *".3. Gifted students tend to manage the information they reveal about their abilities to maintain a great amount of social latitude"*
>
> *".Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)."*

(Miedijensky, 2025)

Insights into Gifted Development: The Influence of Childhood, Learning Environments, and Family from Gifted Adults Perspectives

> *"The term "stigma of giftedness" was first introduced by Coleman in 1985 (Coleman 1985), and later with Cross, he developed the concept in educational settings, how gifted students manage this stigma in social settings through behavior modifications and concealment strategies (Coleman and Cross 1988)."*

(Peairs et al., 2011)

Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence

> *"many gifted youth believe their peers view them as being different (L. J. (Coleman et al., 2014)(Janos et al., 1985), and L. J. (Coleman et al., 2014) suggested that this perceived difference or "stigma of giftedness" interferes with social interaction, whether the stigma is real or only perceived by the gifted adolescent"*
>
> *". gifted adolescents often engage in various social coping strategies to minimize the visibility of their giftedness, including denial of their giftedness, minimizing the visibility of giftedness, increased involvement in socially acceptable compensatory activities, and denying concern about possible social rejection (see, e.g., Cross, Coleman, & Terhaar-Yonkers, 1991;Swiatek, 1995)."*

(Eident et al., 2022)

Examining the Opportunities and Access to Gifted Programs

> *"The article gifted stigma comes from Coleman (1985), who studied how gifted students are perceived by their peers. This article found that even though non-gifted students express mostly positive views toward gifted students, they still would not choose to interact with them or become their friends. In addition, Coleman and Cross (1988) furthered this finding by observing gifted students and finding that gifted students attempted to hide their talents to try and fit in with others."*

(Guthrie, 2019)

"Nothing is ever easy": Parent Perceptions of Intensity in Their Gifted Adolescent Children

> *"some gifted children experience social stigmatization from being labeled gifted (Coleman, 1985;Neihart, 2002;(Swiatek, 1998)"*

(Oh et al., 2019)

Adolescent Perception of Potential High-Performing Classmates: A Cross-National Exploration

> *"(Coleman et al., 2014) indicated that highly able students are conscious of what constitutes appropriate behavior at school. The study noted that gifted students are reluctant to talk about their strengths. Before acknowledging their own positive qualities, these students commonly struggled to neutralize excellent aspects about themselves."*

(Snyder et al., 2013)

Identification as Gifted and Implicit Beliefs About Intelligence: An Examination of Potential Moderators

"Coleman and Cross (1988) proposed that academically gifted students often face a stigma of giftedness, in which they are socially stigmatized due to their academic abilities and experiences. They suggested that gifted students may be aware of this stigma and, therefore, intentionally downplay or hide their giftedness from peers in order to promote social interactions and acceptance. Consistent with this account, some gifted students report withholding effort on tasks to improve peer acceptance (Cross, Coleman, & Stewart, 1993) and discounting the importance of their giftedness as a social identity (Jung, McCormick, & Gross, 2012)."

(Baudson, 2016)

The Mad Genius Stereotype: Still Alive and Well

""Stigma of giftedness" theory posits that stereotyping may lead gifted students to either hide their potential to avoid identification with the stigma, or to overidentify with the label by adopting stereotypical characteristics (Coleman et al., 2014)(Cross, 2005)."

(KONIK, 2023)

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

"Several coping mechanisms are used by students to minimize perceived social stigma, according to early studies on the stigma of giftedness (Buescher, 1985)(Coleman et al., 2014), 2000); (Coleman et al., 1993).These studies claim that gifted children try to cope with their "differentness" by underachieving (Janos et al., 1987), missing to respond to questions in class, asking questions that are not appropriate, acting like the class clown, reducing their vocabulary and lying about getting good grades, making up examinations or assignments to seem tough (Cross et al., 1995), and even denying that they are gifted (Buescher, 1985)"

".Some gifted students believe that they are treated differently and seen as different when others notice their giftedness.(Coleman et al., 2014). Cross et al., 1993;(Manaster et al., 1994)(Manor-Bullock et al., 1995).As a result, these children don't necessarily want to be treated differently or differ intellectually from their peers (Swiatek, 2002)."

(R et al., 2020)

How Can We Better Understand, Identify, and Support Highly Gifted and Profoundly Gifted Students? A Literature Review of the Psychological Development of Highly-Profoundly Gifted Individuals and Overexcitabilities

"Shaklee [35] noted that highly-profoundly gifted children appeared to be in tune with their differences, and intentionally acted "less gifted" around their age-mates"

".Many of the children in Gross's [3] study deliberately underachieved for peer acceptance. The more highly gifted the child, the greater the social pressure to conform or "dumb-down" his or her achievements, thoughts, or behaviors [12,(Gross, 2000)[36][37][38]"

".Going undercover or masking their giftedness may be their best defense or protective coping mechanism (Tolan, 2018)."

(Tourreix et al., 2023)

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

"This idea is described by Coleman andCross (1988, 2014) as the "stigma of giftedness". These authors detail three categories of strategies (visible coping, desertification, and/or camouflage strategies) used by gifted students to manage the information that others have about their giftedness in order to avoid this stigma."

(Chung, 2023)

Portrayal of Gifted Stereotypes in Disney Channel Media

"Previous research reveals that high school gifted students felt stigmatized by peers, teachers, and even parents, consequentially feeling pressured to exhibit one of three behaviors: high visibility, disidentifiers, and invisibility (Coleman et al., 2014)(Berlin, 2009)."

(Schmitt et al., 2023)

Neuromyths and knowledge about intellectual giftedness in a highly educated multilingual country

"also known as the Stigma of Giftedness Paradigm (SPG) (Coleman et al., 2014)(Cross et al., 1993)(Cross et al., 2019)."

(Cross et al., 2019)

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."

(Casino-Garcia et al., 2021)

Emotional Intelligence Profiles and Self-Esteem/Self-Concept: An Analysis of Relationships in Gifted Students

> *"Perceived social competence, as well as other domains of self-concept, may be linked to the strategies students use to face or deny their giftedness, in regard to feeling different [28]."*

(Aziz et al., 2021)

Exploration of Challenges Among Gifted and Talented Children

> *"Gifted people overestimation of others' negative responses toward them may shape their behavior more than other people's actual responses. Therefore, the gifted individuals struggle' with contradictory feelings. While they recognize and appreciate their unique abilities, they are concerned about the social stigma that such abilities may stimulate. On the other hand, some might socially adjust and can be accepted by their peers. Some of them might faces conformity pressures. They might hide their talents in order to be accepted and conform to the peer expectation resulted on developing frustrations, anxiety and depression and resistance to authority (Wright-Scott, 2018)."*